Caldwell may have been, but his championing of Dravidian combined with his church's work in raising the status of lower-caste Christians and in establishing mission schools undoubtedly helped kindle what has been called variously the Dravidian Movement or the Tamil Renaissance.

Today philologists tend to divide the Dravidian family group into four main branches: Northern, Central (Kolami-Parji), South-Central (Telugu-Kui) and South (Tamil-Malayalam-Tulu-Kannada). There is also a growing preference among some South Indians for the dropping of those Sanskrit words Dravidian (as a language group) and Dravidians (as a people) in favour of Tamil and *Tamilakam*, 'the homeland of Tamil'. But that does not go down well with the speakers of other languages that also have a proto-Dravidian origin. This same determination to mark out their own identity gave rise to the agitation among Telugu-speakers that led to the formation of India's newest state of Telangana, formed in June 2014 with Hyderabad as its capital. Not wishing to offend speakers of Malayalam, Telugu or Kannada, I shall stick with 'Dravidian', except when speaking specifically of Tamil country, which is essentially Tamil Nadu (TN) state as it is today.

But Thiruvalluvar's recent elevation off Kanyakumari has come at a price, because his statue quite literally overshadows an even older symbol of the Dravidian South. Robert Foote's drawing from 1860 shows just one solid structure on shore, a low building with red and white striped walls surrounded by a half a dozen mud and palm-leaf huts. This is the ancient shrine of the virgin goddess Devi Kanyakumari, protector of ascetics. The town was her dwelling place long, long before Thiruvalluvar, which explains why Cape Comorin's proper name is Kanyakumari and has been so for at least two thousand years.

In the primordial past, so the Puranas tell us – and Hindu mythology does a far better job in seeking to comprehend the temporal parameters of the cosmos than do the holy